

Is AI's Power Consumption Overhyped?

Posted by u/5ifthwave • 0 points • 33 comments

I've been seeing lots of posts saying using AI is bad for the planet, but they ignore stuff like gaming PCs, fast phone chargers, 4K Netflix, and TVs running all day and even more stuff. So why is asking a bot a question suddenly a climate problem? It feels like people who hype these things up just want to seem like they care about the environment, even though they're still using energy-inefficient electronics. The energy used for one AI answer is tiny, just a rounding error in your electricity bill. Training AI models uses a lot of power, but I'm pretty sure companies try hard to use energy efficiently. Plus, what does that have to do with public using AI? If we really care about energy, shouldn't we look at our everyday electricity use before blaming a chatbot.

What do you think?

Comments

u/scousi • 3 points • 2025-06-08 11:22 UTC

Just a single nvl72 rack from NVidia consumes 120kw. That's enough power to heat 5-6 homes in Canada in winter. A rack is only 2x4x8 ft roughly. That's before the power needed to keep it cool.
<https://www.sunbirdcim.com/blog/your-data-center-ready-nvidia-gb200-nvl72#:~:text=Power.,or%201.2%20kW%20per%20GPU>.

u/SunlitShadows466 • 6 points • 2025-06-08 11:07 UTC

AI training and inference is estimated to be about 10-40 TWh annually. Los Angeles consumes about 20 TWh annually. This is not a small amount of energy.

u/5ifthwave • 0 points • 2025-06-08 11:40 UTC

Nobody is saying it's "no energy consumed", nor do we ask 1 question, but a lot. But there's more to it, even I'm not sure about how to answer all that but what I can say for is we are gonna need more clean energy sources, for the coming future is gonna be really power hungry in every direction.

u/RedTartan04 • 3 points • 2025-06-08 13:11 UTC

Well, you said so in your post.

u/5ifthwave • 0 points • 2025-06-08 14:00 UTC

I said for the regular users using AI it ain't much like it's close to nothing, like the most users waste energy in their households in some form. But

still finite. Tho there's a difference in pow consumption when using AI (like asking questions) vs training it.

But still on a global scale AI uses a lot of power but then we have global scale power wasted in other ways & there are places with power shortages, so we need more sources.

u/mlYuna • 3 points • 2025-06-08 14:21 UTC

The issue is that AI will need to be scaled and we are pouring billions into its development. The power consumption of training AND using AI will become magnitudes more, and no that isn't 'overhyped'.

If AI is using more Energy then entire countries its real bad man... We're already seeing effects across the globe in the latest years of climate change at speeds that we never thought it would come to. The disasters that this will cause in the future are horrible and will affect all of us.

u/5ifthwave • 1 points • 2025-06-08 14:44 UTC

Yes AI definitely needs to be scaled but the effects on climate change that's not just on AI, there's a lot more stuff in play & definitely not just on people prompting, I'm sure it's effect will be greater in coming years, but I still believe effect of using AI will still be lower than complex training & many other computing & other activities around the world. If everyone starts building new AIs that adds to the problem. But as of now I think effects on climate change has much more contributors than just the public's use of AI (I'm not even talking about Training).

u/Fickle-Lifeguard-356 • 2 points • 2025-06-08 11:06 UTC

Just imagine how much energy is consumed by constantly crawling through very poorly optimized web pages that don't even make it around the world without javascript.

u/5ifthwave • 1 points • 2025-06-08 11:33 UTC

Yes AI consumes a lot, but more than that all the households consume combined right? Should that be against AI usage? I mean it must work to be better & there must be better sources of power for it too.

u/AnnualAdventurous169 • 6 points • 2025-06-08 10:32 UTC

it may be over hyped buy you are really underselling how much it uses. Its uses up so power that the current grid cannot keep up with demand. Microsoft is considering spinning up a nuclear power pland to power their AI server farms and Elmo is using incredibly poluting and inefficient mtethane power generators to run Grok and that is having real health effects on people in menphis. ,

u/stoppableDissolution • 0 points • 2025-06-08 10:46 UTC

Nuclear = good tho.

u/RedTartan04 • 0 points • 2025-06-08 12:56 UTC

Nuclear good? Ridiculous. When I was a kid we couldn't drink milk because of Tschenobyl had blown up - 1000 miles away. We still can't eat mushrooms off some forests - almost 40 years later. Now Saporischschja is threatened by the psycho in the Krmlin. Oh, that's not the US I hear you saying? Well, M\$ is reactivating Three Mile Island - how studpid is that??

u/stoppableDissolution • 1 points • 2025-06-08 13:12 UTC

I grew up 350km away from Chernobyl. So?

Modern reactors are physically incapable of spiraling out into meltdown, unlike the old ones. Heck, Zaporizje you brought in has been shelled and could not care less. You need a lot of deliberate effort (direct nuke hit level) to cause some kind of damage, and radioactive pollution from coal used to make "green" energy sources in China is higher than from Fukushima. And nuclear "waste" is just fuel that is not commercially viable to use yet, with technology already in place (fast breeders).

Nuclear fearmongering is the same kind as plane one. Both are perceived to be dangerous, when statistics says the opposite.

u/RedTartan04 • -1 points • 2025-06-08 13:48 UTC

Fukushima reactors where top-notch stuff. Three reactors melted. No moderated chain reaction is safe.

"waste is just fuel..." Good luck getting the dumped or buried nuclear waste out again later. We have a former salt mine nearby where they dumped 120,000 crates containing nuclear waste in the 1970s. 30 years ago they noticed movement underground and now water is inceasingly leaking in, endangering ground water in a well-populated and agriculturally rich area. After various examinations and concepts since then, it became clear, the waste has to get out. They're currently preparing that and it'll take another 10 years and costs 3 billion Euros - just the preparation to get it out! All in all it's estimated to 6 billion Euros. Just to get it OUT. There is no place to securely store the sht so they'll just store it a building nearby. House prices are plummeting, people are moving away. - and that nuclear waste is not even from power plants! It's "just" 'weakly radioactive' from research and medical facilities. So

keep on dreaming in your lobby-washed mind.
Ignorance is bliss.

u/AnnualAdventurous169 • 1 points • 2025-06-08 11:04 UTC

Yes, but very expensive, for it to be even a consideration is a indicator of just how power hungry ai is

u/5ifthwave • -3 points • 2025-06-08 10:37 UTC

Should we stop using AI tho? Problems leads to solutions, they might find solution for the consumption, but like how much for a regular person using AI? it's basically a tiny bit off their electricity bills.

I understand a single grid might be overloaded, but that shouldn't be against AIs.